



The Secret of the Roots & Shoots

By Liezl Coetzee



In the heart of the dusty city,
behind a rusted iron gate,
Arvid and Liora found
something impossible. A
wild, hidden garden was
breathing in the shadows.
The air smelled of damp
earth and sweet blossoms.
Arvid pushed through the
ivy, his eyes wide. "It's like
the earth has a secret," he
whispered. Liora followed,
her fingers brushing the
vibrant green leaves. They





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As they explored, they met Saffron, who was already busy filling a wicker basket. "Look!" Saffron called out, pointing to a tree heavy with fruit. "The bright red globes are apples for crunch, and those yellow drops are lemons for zing!" Arvid picked an apple, noticing how its skin shone. Saffron explained that nature provides everything we need, and every bite of real





"But what about these?"

Liora asked, kneeling by a patch of low-growing plants. Saffron smiled.

"Those are wild greens! This one with the thick, juicy leaves is Spekboom, and the little succulent one is Purslane." They learned that these weren't just weeds; they were secret treasures packed with vitamins. Liora carefully tucked a sprig of Purslane behind her ear,





Suddenly, Arvid yelped and pulled back his hand. "Ouch! This one bites!" He had brushed against a tall, fuzzy plant. "Ah, the Nettle," Liora said, remembering a story her grandmother told. "It stings if you're not careful, but once it's prepared, it's one of the strongest medicines in the garden." They learned that food is medicine, and even the prickliest plants can help the



Saffron led them to a wooden table in the center of the clearing. "Nature provides everything," she said, "but we have to be the alchemists." She showed Arvid how the roots and shoots work together. They gathered flatleaf parsley, curly parsley, and mint. Saffron explained the golden rule: Good Food leads to Strong Bodies, and Strong Bodies lead to Happy Hearts.





It was time for the Great Smoothie Experiment. Liora and Arvid gathered the basics: half a banana for creaminess, half an apple for sweetness, and a big handful of emerald-green spinach. "Now for the magic," Arvid said, dropping in five wild green leaves they had found. They added a squeeze of fresh lemon and a splash of cool water, watching as the colors began to swirl





Saffron joined in, adding the final touch—three sprigs of fresh mint. As they blended the mixture, the kitchen filled with a refreshing, bright scent. "This is how we drink the garden's energy," Saffron said. They watched the liquid turn a vibrant, glowing green. It wasn't just a drink; it was a potion for health, designed to make them feel like they could run for miles.





"Now we need something for the road," Arvid suggested. They decided to make a 'Superhero Sprinkle.' Arvid and Saffron gathered superfoods: pomegranates, berries, and more wild greens like plantain and nettle. They talked about how these small things hold big magic. By drying them out and crushing them, they could create a sprinkle of goodness to add to any meal,





As the sun began to set,
Saffron and Liora sat in the
garden, feeling strong and
content. They had learned
that the Earth is a pharmacy
and a kitchen all in one.
With their bellies full of
greens and their hearts full
of joy, they knew this was
just the beginning of their
journey from soil to soul.
"Good food, strong bodies,"
Liora whispered. "And very,
very happy hearts," Saffron

